

HORIZON-WIDERA-2021-ERA-01-90: The challenges of research ethics and integrity in response to crisis: the coronavirus pandemic and beyond

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 4.50 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 4.50 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions
<i>Eligibility conditions</i>	The conditions are described in General Annex B. The following exceptions apply: Legal entities established in non-associated third countries may exceptionally participate in this Coordination and support action. Due to the scope of this topic, in addition to the minimum number of participants set out in the General Annexes, proposals must include at least two participants from China, Korea and/or African countries non-associated to Horizon Europe. Participants from countries, which are not eligible for funding according to the General Annexes, may take part in the project as associated partners.
<i>Legal and financial set-up of the Grant Agreements</i>	The rules are described in General Annex G. The following exceptions apply: Beneficiaries will be subject to the following additional dissemination obligations: Proposals must include structured cooperation with the e-platform

	Embassy of Good Science⁵⁰, and the European Networks ENERI (European Network of Research Ethics Committees and Research Integrity Offices)⁵¹ and ENRIO (European Network of Research Integrity Offices)⁵². The output material of the action must be made available on the e-platform Embassy of Good Science.
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Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following expected outcomes:

Crises, and in particular health related ones, have become a dramatic reality for the EU and globally since the beginning of the coronavirus pandemic. Scientific knowledge focuses the attention, as it is a key element to address the urgency of the situation in an effective way and improve preparedness for the future. The extremely heavy human, social, cultural and economic consequences associated with the time pressure sets exceptional conditions calling for an adaptation of the way and procedures to work, and decide and prioritise which inevitably raises associated ethical questions. Some research topics have an intrinsically complex ethics dimension, for example research on the imposing of protection measures, health care prioritization, consequences for family life, and gender impacts on health.

In this context, the activity proposed is expected to propose an operational ethics and integrity framework, which preserves the key ethics principles while supporting a rapid and effective response to a crisis and improving overall preparedness.

Scope: The first priority is to analyse what characterises, from an ethics perspective, a crisis of a global, sudden and unexpected nature of the type of the Covid-19 pandemic, and isolate what are the related ethics and integrity challenges as regards the production, sharing and use of scientific knowledge and data⁵³ in designing and implementing responses as well as in anticipating future global urgencies.

Derogations of human rights and freedoms, albeit in the interests of the public good, must be temporary, proportionate, used only as last resort, and critically there must be clear transparent criteria for their suspension e.g. in the form of sunset clauses to emergency legislation. The greatest danger – during and after the end of any formal ‘state of emergency’ – is a ‘new normal’ of eroded rights and liberties.⁵⁴ For example, the pressing need to collect large amounts of personal data raises important questions regarding the preservation of

⁵⁰ www.embassy.science

⁵¹ <http://eneri.eu/>

⁵² <http://www.enrio.eu/>

⁵³ The need for the sharing of data was emphasised in the Commission Communication on the on additional COVID-19 response measures, COM(2020) 687 final, <https://ec.europa.eu/info/sites/info/files/communication-additional-covid-19-response-measures.pdf>

⁵⁴ Statement on European Solidarity and the Protection of Fundamental Rights in the COVID-19 Pandemic, European Group on Ethics in Science and New Technologies https://ec.europa.eu/info/sites/info/files/research_and_innovation/eg_ege-statement-covid-19.pdf

privacy⁵⁵, and should be assessed carefully against the need to ensure information of data subjects and the possibility to pursue alternative means.

An important element that characterises major crises is that they go beyond the impact on the wellbeing of persons and touches the society more globally notably in terms of solidarity and social justice, as well as gender equality. Mid and long-term social, cultural and economic consequences are also more prominent in these unusual research contexts. The issues related to the role of ethics and integrity experts (as advisors, for example), informed consent, undue inducement, the right to know, and to opt out should be among the elements to tackle.

Based on this analysis, the action should draw the lessons and examine how to adapt processes followed under normal conditions (e.g. for informed consent, regulatory approvals etc.).

The scope should also cover the ethics of the scientific work on public health measures (such as behavioural studies, communication strategies, gender impacts on health⁵⁶), including those aiming at an increased preparedness. The objective is to cover emerging ethics issues related to new concepts like “immunisation certification” that are at the centre of vivid debates involving fundamental values.

The action should clearly highlight what cannot be accepted or neglected in the name of coping with the urgency and the magnitude of the impact of a crisis (including the moral distress of the front line personnel, a large majority of which are women). Another important example is the need to always conduct, prior to the start of a research, an independent ethical review, which remains a necessary safeguard for the individuals involved and enhance the trust from the impacted communities and the society as a whole⁵⁷. Emergency needs adaptation should not lower ethics and integrity standards.

The work should be based on existing know how and identification of preparedness need. The joint advice on “Improving Pandemic Preparedness and Management”⁵⁸ by the Group of Chief Scientific Advisors (GCSA), the European Group on Ethics in Science and New Technologies (EGE) and Peter Piot, special advisor to the President of the European Commission, should be considered. In a bottom-up approach, involving all relevant stakeholders (e.g. researchers, research funders, policy-makers, publishers and citizens) through the organisation of participatory events (workshops, consultations, ‘town hall’ meetings) the activities should propose ways and means to encourage changes in the research culture, and promote openness, communication and dialogue. This must be done in cooperation with ENRIO (European Network of Research Integrity Offices)⁵⁹ and ENERI

⁵⁵ The full respect of the data protection law with regard to contact tracing technologies was reaffirmed in the Commission Communication on the additional COVID-19 response measures.

⁵⁶ See European Institute for Gender Equality (2020) Covid-19 and gender equality, <https://eige.europa.eu/topics/health/covid-19-and-gender-equality>.

⁵⁷ Ibid. The Commission Communication calls for a “robust authorisation process” to ensure safety.

⁵⁸ <https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/a1016d77-2562-11eb-9d7e-01aa75ed71a1/language-en/format-PDF/source-171481573>

⁵⁹ <http://www.enrio.eu/>